What Is Prior Authorization?

Patient education article | October 24, 2026 | Raj Dutt Sharma

Prior authorization is approval from your health insurance plan that may be required before you receive certain medical care, treatments, or medications.

Your healthcare provider requests approval for care they believe is medically necessary. Your insurer reviews whether it meets the plan's coverage requirements.

If approved, your care can typically move forward. But remember, even with prior authorization, your insurance may not pay for everything or, depending on your circumstances, may not pay at all.

Prior authorization is also known as preauthorization, precertification, or prior approval.

Why Do Health Plans Require Prior Authorization?

Health plans use prior authorization to review medical necessity and coverage requirements. It is often required for expensive treatments, those with lower-cost alternatives, or those involving greater medical risks.

However, prior authorization can delay treatment while patients wait for a decision, especially if the insurer requests additional medical documentation.

What Kinds of Care Often Need Prior Authorization?

Requirements vary by plan, but these services may need approval:

- **Imaging tests**, such as MRI, CT, and PET scans
- **Planned surgeries and hospital stays**
- **Certain prescription drugs**, especially specialty medications
- **Physical, occupational, and speech therapy**, particularly after a certain number of visits
- **Durable medical equipment**, such as wheelchairs, CPAP machines, or hospital beds
- **Home health care and skilled nursing services**

Emergency medical care does not require prior authorization. If you are experiencing a medical emergency, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency room.

How Does the Prior Authorization Process Work?

Here is what typically happens:

1. **Your doctor recommends care.** They check whether your insurance requires prior authorization.
2. **The office submits a request.** It includes your diagnosis and relevant medical information.
3. **Your insurer reviews the request.** They may ask your doctor for additional documentation.
4. **You receive a decision.** Your insurer notifies you and your doctor whether the request is approved, partially approved, or denied.
5. **You arrange your care.** Once approved, you can generally schedule your procedure or arrange to have your prescription filled.

How Long Does Prior Authorization Take?

Requests may take longer when additional medical information is needed.

If waiting could seriously harm your health, your doctor can request an urgent (expedited) review.

As of January 2026, federal rules generally require Medicare Advantage and Medicaid plans to decide standard requests for medical services and equipment within seven calendar days and urgent requests within 72 hours. Certain extensions and exceptions may apply.

Prescription drugs follow separate rules. Other health insurance plans may have different timelines, so check with your insurer.

What If My Prior Authorization Request Is Denied?

A denial does not mean the end of your options. Your insurer must explain the denial and your appeal rights.

- **Consult with your doctor.** They may submit more information or suggest a covered alternative.
- **Ask about a peer-to-peer review.** Depending on your plan, your doctor may be able to discuss your case with an insurer's medical professional.
- **File an appeal.** Follow the instructions and deadlines in your denial notice. Keep copies of your documents.
- **Request an independent review.** If your appeal is denied, you may qualify for an outside review.

Tips to Avoid Prior Authorization Delays

- Ask whether authorization is required before scheduling care.
- Call the member services number on your insurance card.
- Record the request's submission date and reference number.
- Follow up if your insurer misses the expected decision timeframe.
- Confirm required approval before receiving non-emergency care.

Frequently Asked Questions About Prior Authorization

Do I need to request prior authorization myself?

Usually not. Your doctor's office typically submits the request. You can contact your insurer to check its status.

Does approval mean my care is free?

No. You may still owe a copay, coinsurance, or deductible.

Does approval last forever?

Not necessarily. Approval terms vary by treatment and insurance plan.

What happens if I change health insurance plans?

Your new plan may require authorization. However, Medicare Advantage plans generally provide at least 90 days of transition protection for ongoing treatment when switching plans. Tell your doctor about coverage changes to avoid interruptions in care.

SEO & Editorial Approach

A compact content brief accompanying the patient-facing article. This is an independent portfolio sample, not content published on behalf of a hospital or insurer.

OBJECTIVE

Explain a complicated health insurance process in plain language while addressing common patient questions about approval, timing, cost, and appeals.

AUDIENCE & SEARCH INTENT

Patients and caregivers seeking an informational overview before receiving treatment or contacting a health plan.

PRIMARY KEYWORD

prior authorization

SUPPORTING SEARCH TERMS

what is prior authorization; prior authorization process; how long does prior authorization take; prior authorization denied

PROPOSED SEO TITLE

What Is Prior Authorization? A Patient's Guide for 2026

PROPOSED META DESCRIPTION

Learn how prior authorization works, which treatments require approval, how long requests take, and what to do if your health insurance denies coverage.

PROPOSED URL SLUG

/what-is-prior-authorization/

ON-PAGE APPROACH

Place the central definition first. Use descriptive H2 questions, a five-step process, scannable examples, action-oriented tips, and concise FAQs. Integrate terms naturally without making unverified ranking claims.

ACCURACY & EDITORIAL REVIEW

Reviewed federal guidance current through October 24, 2026. The 2026 seven-day and 72-hour decision limits cited in the article concern covered non-drug medical items and services, with applicable exceptions and extensions.

RESEARCH REFERENCES

CMS: Improving Prior Authorization Processes

HealthCare.gov: Preauthorization

Medicare.gov: Special Needs Plans